CHAPTER 50

600

21–25 August 2020

ENGLAND vs PAKISTAN, 3rd Test, *Rose Bowl*, *Southampton*

England 583/8 dec.; Pakistan 273 and 187/4 (following on)

Match drawn

England 1st innings: **Z Crawley 267 and J Buttler 152**

Pakistan 1st innings: **A Ali 141 n.o.**

Pakistan 2nd innings: **A Ali c Root b Anderson 31** (600th Test wicket)

The country is locked down and cricket dissolves into the air as if it is from a hazy past life. We are delighted when Pakistan and West Indies agree to come to England to tour. Most of the UK, and the rest of the world for that matter, is in isolation, all in varying degrees of boredom or distress, yet we are going to be allowed to play. It becomes almost like some small version of National Service, to give people something to watch that is happening out in the world and try to impart a feeling of normality into their lives. The protocols are tight and intense. We are tested multiple times daily, masks are required to always be worn when we're indoors and we must always stay at the grounds we are playing at, never being allowed out of the rooms. We eat individually, with screens separating each of us. The only saving grace is that the rooms often have balconies, meaning we can pop our heads out and sit there, talking, as if we're cellmates trying to squeeze our heads through bars, hatching our plans to escape.

It's the last Test before everyone can finally get home to see their families. The isolation and the eerie repetition of completely empty grounds has given the series an apocalyptic feel, even if it's a lifeline to cricket fans